

THE SILHOUETTE FALLACY

A play for two people

Wheeler Hubbell

WHEELER HUBBELL PUBLISHING

UNIT 1: BROKEN / DIFFERENT

Part 1 of 3

The stage is silent. JUSTIN stands in the light. He is not doing anything. He is staring at his hands.

WHEELER sits in the chair, outside the light, a notepad on his lap. He is waiting.

JUSTIN

Something in my brain is broken.

WHEELER

Broken?

JUSTIN

Different.

WHEELER

That was fast.

JUSTIN

It took thirty nine years.

A pause. JUSTIN looks at the lamp, not at

WHEELER.

WHEELER

What is different?

THE SILHOUETTE FALLACY

JUSTIN

Turns out I don't know what I've already thought until I hear
myself say it out loud.

WHEELER

So speaking helps you think.

JUSTIN

No.

The thinking has already happened.

WHEELER

Then what does speaking do?

JUSTIN

Shows me the shape.

WHEELER

Of the thought.

JUSTIN

Of what was already holding me up.

A pause.

JUSTIN

The thinking is support beams.
I say it out loud and realize they connect.

WHEELER

Into what?

JUSTIN

A bridge.

WHEELER

To what?

THE SILHOUETTE FALLACY

JUSTIN
Legibility.

*His hand begins to move—a rhythmic, unconscious
gesture. He notices it. He stops.*

WHEELER
Why did you stop?

JUSTIN
Because that hand gets called something before anyone can hear
the thought.

WHEELER
Called what?

JUSTIN
Faggy.

A pause.

WHEELER
The hand?

JUSTIN
The wrist. If it went loose.

His hand moves again. This time he watches it.

JUSTIN
A little boy in Virginia is not allowed to talk that much.
Especially if he sounds like a girl. He is not allowed to move his
hands like that. Somebody sees the movement before they can
hear the thought, and suddenly the movement means something
disgusting about him.

WHEELER
They were correcting how you presented the thought.

THE SILHOUETTE FALLACY

JUSTIN

No.

WHEELER

What were they correcting?

JUSTIN

The only route it had.

A pause.

JUSTIN

They weren't making fun of the thought.

They couldn't hear it yet.

WHEELER

They interrupted the bridge.

JUSTIN

Yes.

A longer pause.

WHEELER

And what did you learn?

JUSTIN

Shut up.

Hold your hands still.

Do not let the process become visible.

WHEELER takes a sheet of paper.

JUSTIN

What are you doing?

WHEELER

Writing down what arrived first.

THE SILHOUETTE FALLACY

He writes in large block letters on the paper:

TOO MUCH

He sets the paper on the table. He leaves it unplaced.

WHEELER

Did it work?

JUSTIN

What?

WHEELER

Holding still.

A pause.

JUSTIN

Yes.

WHEELER

What stopped?

JUSTIN

The hand.

WHEELER

And the thought?

JUSTIN

Eventually.

A pause.

JUSTIN

I learned to shut up. I held my hands still. I made sure I never looked too excited, too expressive, too much like whatever they had decided I was not allowed to be.

THE SILHOUETTE FALLACY

WHEELER

And then you could think?

JUSTIN

No.

His hand begins to move. He stops it again.

JUSTIN

The thinking was still there.

It was holding everything up.

But I couldn't see how the beams connected.

WHEELER

What could you see?

JUSTIN

The correction.

WHEELER

Which correction?

JUSTIN

You missed something.

You are behind.

Everyone else understands.

Fix it.

Watch your face.

Watch your voice.

Watch your hands.

Do not stop checking yourself for one second.

A pause.

WHEELER

Who was saying that?

THE SILHOUETTE FALLACY

JUSTIN
Eventually?

WHEELER
Yes.

JUSTIN
Me.

A longer pause.

JUSTIN
I became the person interrupting the thought.

WHEELER reaches toward TOO MUCH.

JUSTIN
Not yet.

WHEELER stops.

WHEELER
Why?

JUSTIN
It has not become me yet.

Blackout.